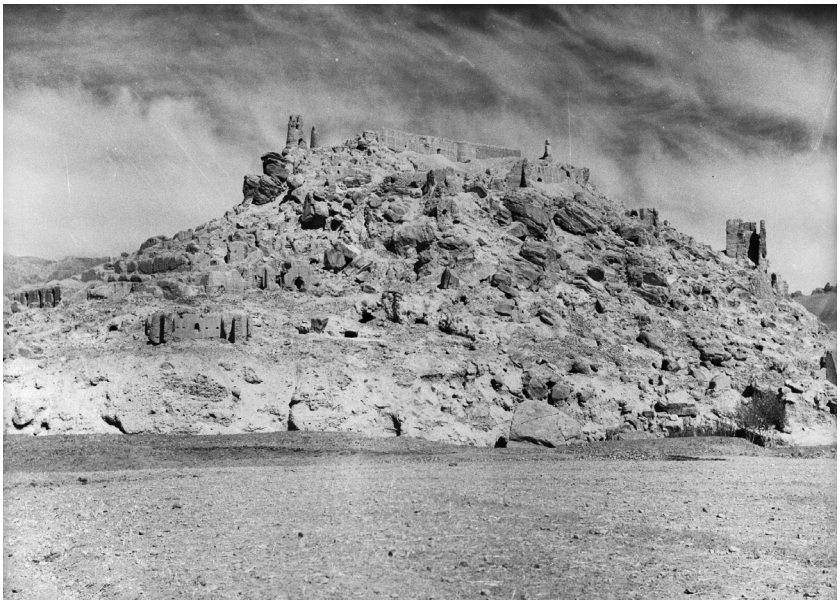


Figure 3.12 *Shahr-i Gholghola, general view, citadel (eleventh–thirteenth century). © Photograph Josephine Powell* c. *1960. Harvard Fine Arts Library, Special Collections.*

to attain chronological and functional understandings of the many ruins atop these western promontories. Nevertheless, for now it is plausible that initial construction in these areas came about sometime in the pre-Islamic centuries, possibly during the proposed expansion of architectural activity into the surrounding valleys as the Western Turks extended their reach southward throughout Tukharistan and consolidated their presence in Bamiyan (see above).

The surface decorations on many structural remains (Figure 3.15) have been described as "characteristic Ghurid geometrical pattern[s] composed of lines of incised triangles." But given the enduring use of similar architectural decorations even into the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, they are far from diagnostic of chronology. Indeed, the complexes' structural techniques (Figures 3.16 and 3.17) as well as the remnants of interior painted decorations (Figure 3.18) are instead indicative of initial construction in the pre-Islamic centuries of the mid-first millennium CE.[62] As was the case with most of the other hilltop complexes throughout the Bamiyan region, these western sites were in all likelihood also reused and possibly repurposed throughout the following centuries, making archaeological excavation and analysis all the more necessary for precise dating.[63]

Another complex indicating twelfth-century occupation is Barfak II, also known as Danestama, located to the northeast of Bamiyan on the right bank of the Surkhab River (Figures 3.19–3.22). While the overall site com-